studies of elliptic and theta functions, determinant and matrix theory, and bilinear forms. Some fifteen years later, Kronecker's passing opened a vacant slot in Berlin, and Weierstrass got posthumous revenge on his old opponent by hiring his own student, Frobenius, for Kronecker's chair. In 1892 Frobenius left for Berlin, just four years before Einstein enrolled as a student in the Zürich Polytechnikum.

Praised by his colleagues as "a first-rate stylist", who "writes clearly and understandably without ever attempting to delude the reader with empty phrases", Frobenius was soon elected to the prestigious Prussian Academy of Sciences [**11**, p. 38]. At this point, Frobenius began reevaluating his research interests. As he explained in his inaugural speech, the "labyrinth of formulas" in the theory of theta functions was having "a withering effect upon the mathematical imagination". He intended "to overcome this paralysis of the mathematical creative powers by time and again seeking renewal at the fountain of youth of arithmetic", i.e., number theory (quoted in [**24**, p. 220]). In his 40s, Frobenius indeed found this "fountain of youth" in "arithmetic", that is, in the theory of finite groups linked to the theory of numbers by Galois theory.

In 1896 Frobenius's comfortable life in Berlin was unceremoniously disrupted by several letters from Richard Dedekind, his old acquaintance and a predecessor at the Zürich Polytechnikum, now the dean of abstract algebra in Germany. After dealing with epistolary niceties and thanking Frobenius for brightening "the African darkness of the theory of groups", Dedekind shared some of his recent results on group theory, including his concept of the group determinant and the statement of his theorem about its factorization for abelian groups. Since Dedekind had not bothered to publish his work on the topic, Frobenius had never even heard of the group determinant, but he quickly grasped this concept and never let it go again. In his reply, Frobenius mildly chastised Dedekind for keeping back these "extremely beautiful results from your friends and admirers", and asked for more details. Dedekind then stumped his colleague with a "conjectured theorem" that the number of linear factors in